of bloggers and activists being abducted by '*namaloom afraad*' or the *'khalai makhlouq*'[5] for their online activity. The chapter also examines student narratives from the 2015–16 student survey in Lahore and Karachi in relation to social media, especially Facebook, to understand how students (among the urban youth) use social media, and the extent to which this medium of communication has the potential to promote political activism offline.

Social media engagement

> *Yes, Facebook posts and statuses keep us aware about political situation to some extent.*
>
> (Student, Female, Lahore)

The Janus-faced nature of social media is evident in the role of social networking websites such as Facebook in the Cambridge Analytica scandal[6], and its ability to promote real-world activism and reporting during the Arab Spring (Brown et al. 2012; Eltantawy and Wiest 2011); the anti-austerity protests in Europe (Cristancho 2015); and the live streaming of police brutality in the Black Lives Matter movement in the United States. India is another example where social media was instrumental in promoting mobilization for the 2011 anti-corruption movement and the mass mobilization against sexual violence and rape during the Delhi gang rape case in 2012. Yet, in the same year it also proved lethal in spreading fake news that resulted in exacerbating the ethnic conflict in Assam and the Muzzafarnagar riots in 2013[7] (Bute 2014). In Pakistan, social media sites such as Twitter have been instrumental in promoting the PTM as broadcasting media were banned from airing any reports about the movement. It has also provided a space for journalists to circulate news articles or op-eds that were blocked from being printed by news conglomerates. Kleinhans et al.'s (2015) research highlights the power of 'ICT [information and communication technology], social media and mobile technologies' to 'alter the larger context of public participation' by opening 'up new possibilities for policy-makers' as well as empowering and fostering 'the self-organization of citizens' (2015, p. 240). It is not meant to replace 'real-world' activities and participation but rather provide another avenue through which these activities can be improved. This is evident in the use of social media by political actors (see Howard et al. 2016). Blogs, 'the Social Media equivalent of personal web pages' (Kaplan and Haenlein 2010, p. 63), and Twitter, 'an information transmission channel'